

Learning With Music: Top 10 TikTok Songs [B2]

Oggi, sono le reti sociali a decidere il successo di una canzone, non importa se sia moderna o di sessant'anni fa!

The world's most downloaded app in the last five years, TikTok was launched less than a decade ago in China and rapidly changed how young people discover new music. Short [quirky](#) videos of dance moves or challenges are accompanied by [snippets](#) of songs, creating a trend where users upload their own versions. As the videos become viral, so do the songs. Many [savvy](#) artists have realised the influence of the app, most famously rapper Lil Nas X, whose Old Town Road spent a record nineteen weeks at Number One in the US in 2019 after he launched an online challenge. Last year the platform [claimed](#) that "84 per cent of songs that entered the Billboard Global 200 in 2024 went viral on TikTok first." It has, more notably, revived the fortunes of older songs, both famous and obscure — its most streamed song of 2025 was Connie Francis' Pretty Little Baby, an almost unknown album track recorded over six decades earlier.

1. PRETTY LITTLE BABY, CONNIE FRANCIS (1962)

American singer Connie Francis was hugely successful in the early days of pop music but Pretty Little Baby was an [overlooked](#) album track. This changed last year when users and influencers such as Kim Kardashian and Kylie Jenner began to upload videos [lipsynching](#) to [cute](#) babies. The lyrics, almost all in the present simple and continuous, are a simple expression of young love. The singer, who passed away last July, was [delighted](#) with the resurgence but admitted that not only had she never heard of TikTok, she had forgotten the song existed! You can ask the flowers, I sit for hours Tellin' all the [bluebirds](#), the [bill and coo birds](#) Pretty little baby I'm so in love with you

2. TURN THE LIGHTS OFF, KATO (2010)

A TikTok meme of American actor Jon Hamm dancing to [Danish](#) disc jockey Kato's Turn The Lights Off in the Apple TV series Your Friends & Neighbors [spawned](#) a [slew](#) of [copycat](#) videos in 2025. It subsequently became a club favourite and climbed the international charts. The lyrics open with two imperatives and an often-used abbreviation of 'because'. I said ooh-ooh Come on, baby, turn the lights off Ooh-ooh 'Cause it's getting late

3. HARNESS YOUR HOPES, PAVEMENT (1999)

An unlikely viral hit, this was a B-side for American indie band Pavement, who [disbanded](#) the same year. Singer Stephen Malkmus discovered the song's [belated](#) 2020 success when he heard it playing in a local [bakery](#) and was told TikTok users were dancing to it. This led to a successful reunion tour for the band. The song had a second resurgence in 2024 when it accompanied users showing off their [outfits](#). The lyrics have examples of positive and negative imperatives. [Harness](#) your hopes On just one person Because you know a [harness](#) Was only made for one Don't telegraph your passes You'll end up with [molasses](#)

4. BLOODY MARY, LADY GAGA (2010)

Although not featured in the 2022 Netflix comedy horror series Wednesday, fans began to recreate the dance scene using a [sped-up](#) version of this Lady Gaga album track. Its popularity [prompted](#) its [release](#) as a single twelve years after its recording. The lyrics contrast the initial spontaneity of the future 'will' with the 'going to' for intentions, as well as the informal use of "like someone said" instead of "as someone said." I'll dance, dance, dance With my hands, hands, hands Above my head, head, head Like Jesus said I'm gonna dance, dance, dance With my hands, hands, hands above my head

5. FOREVER YOUNG, ALPHAVILLE (1984)

The third single by German band Alphaville has soundtracked various trending videos, from slow-motion footage of couples [swinging](#) a water bottle to montages of users getting older. The band's singer posted a video of scenes of his daughter growing up, saying he "[hopped on the beam](#)" (meaning he joined the trend.) The song's chorus features an example of a yes/no question with auxiliary. So many dreams [swinging out of the blue](#) We let them come true Forever young, I want to be forever young Do you really want to live forever, forever and ever? Entertainment

Learning With Music: Top 10 Love Songs Non c'è niente di più romantico che dedicare una canzone d'amore. Eccone 10 intramontabili con cui fare colpo! Fergal Kavanagh , Sarah Davison

6. YOUNGEST DAUGHTER, SUPERHEAVEN (2013)

This album track revived the fortunes of semi-retired American alternative rock band Superheaven. Its emotional lyrics, almost entirely in the present simple, [resonated with](#) youngest daughters when it was featured in several videos a decade after its [release](#). It became the band's most-streamed song and [prompted](#) them to [resume](#) touring. It's useless, I tried, but [to no avail](#) To tell you how much I know, how much I care

7. APPLE, CHARLI XCX (2024)

British singer Charli xcx's last album "[Brat](#)" was a huge success, partly because of an aggressive marketing campaign but mainly thanks to TikTok. New York-based influencer Kelley Heyer felt that one track, Apple, was not getting the attention it [deserved](#) and created a set of dance moves. These soon became viral and the song [shot into](#) the charts. The lyrics are in the present simple with examples of informal English. I think the apple's [rotten right to the core](#) From all the things passed down From all the apples coming before I [split](#) the apple down symmetrical lines And what I find is kinda scary Makes me just wanna drive

8. DREAMS, FLEETWOOD MAC (1977)

In 2020 a middle-aged American filmed himself skateboarding while drinking from a juice bottle, [mouthing](#) this classic song. The twenty-two-second video immediately went viral and the song was streamed a record number of times, returning to the charts. Users [rushed](#) to upload their own versions, including the band's seventy-three-year-old drummer Mick Fleetwood! The [deceptively](#) simple lyrics feature useful expressions and idioms. Now here you go again You say you want your freedom Well, who am I to [keep you down](#) It's only right that you should Play the way you feel it

9. KILLING ME SOFTLY, FUGEES (1996)

When American hip-hop group Fugees recorded this cover, already a huge hit for Roberta Flack in 1973, it became 1996's [biggest-selling](#) single worldwide. It has [swept through](#) TikTok several times — one remix accompanied a [shuffle dance](#) trend and another was part of a walking challenge. The title features an adverb and the chorus is in the present continuous, giving immediacy and intimacy to the song. [Strumming](#) my pain with his fingers Singing my life with his words Killing me softly with his song Killing me softly with his song Telling my whole life with his words Killing me softly with his song

10. RUNNING UP THAT HILL, KATE BUSH (1985)

Now forever associated with Netflix series Stranger Things, this 80s single went viral in 2022 and gave Kate Bush her second UK number one a record forty-four years after her first (with Wuthering Heights.) Highlighting the platform's musical importance, one report [claimed](#) that 39 per cent of Generation Z only recognise the song from TikTok. The chorus features an example of the second conditional. And if I only could I'd [make a deal](#) with God And I'd get Him to [swap](#) our places I'd be runnin' up that road Be runnin' up that hill With no problems Click here and listen to the Spotify playlist with the Top 10 TikTok songs. Fergal Kavanagh runs the website www.tuneintoenglish.com, the web's largest free resource for

learning English through pop music. [Click here](#) and you'll have access to the worksheets for the songs included in this article.

Glossary

- **outfits** = abbinamenti
- **out of the blue** = all'improvviso, dal nulla
- **keep you down** = reprimere, trattenere
- **overlooked** = trascurare, ignorare
- **copycat** = copie, imitatori
- **molasses** = melassa
- **release** = uscita
- **to no avail** = inutilmente
- **shot into** = balzare, schizzare in
- **rotten** = marcia
- **deceptively** = apparentemente
- **Harness** = incanalare
- **split** = dividere
- **make a deal** = fare un patto
- **swap** = scambiare
- **quirky** = stravaganti
- **spawned** = dare origine a
- **harness** = imbracatura, cintura
- **resonated with** = entrare in sintonia con
- **biggest-selling** = più venduto
- **snippets** = frammenti
- **savvy** = astuti
- **bakery** = panetteria
- **sped-up** = accelerata
- **hopped on the beam** = unirsi al trend
- **claimed** = affermare
- **Danish** = danese
- **slew** = gran quantità
- **deserved** = meritare
- **mouthng** = muovere le labbra, fare finta di cantare
- **shuffle dance** = danza shuffle
- **Strumming** = strimpellare
- **lipsynching** = cantare in playback, sincronizzare le labbra

- **delighted** = entusiasta
- **bill and coo birds** = uccelli che strofinano il becco e tubano
- **disbanded** = sciogliersi
- **belated** = tardivo
- **prompted** = provocare
- **swinging** = oscillare
- **right to the core** = fino al midollo
- **bluebirds** = uccellini
- **resume** = riprendere
- **Brat** = monella, viziata, sfacciata
- **rushed** = precipitarsi
- **swept through** = diffondersi
- **cute** = adorabili